

FOREWORD

One hundred years ago the world was a very different place. The United States was emerging as a world economic power, but had yet to realize its full potential. Europe was at peace, tenuous as it was, while trouble in Russia was a portent of war and revolution to come. Much of the rest of the world remained as either economic or political colonies of the dominant powers.

Millions of Europe and Asia's poor continued to travel days and weeks by steamship to seek a new life in the

CAPTIVATING SPECTACLE

Straining to see over the perimeter fence, spectators gaze in wonder at the aircraft on display at the Hendon airfield, England, in 1911. By capturing the public's imagination, early aviators inspired an enthusiasm for flight that would outlast the century.

United States. Once there, steam-driven trains were the primary means of long-distance overland transport for immigrant and citizen alike. The vast rail network linked most communities and enabled those who could afford it to ride across the country in less than a week. Nevertheless, once settled, most Americans stayed at home and few ever traveled more than 25 miles from their place of birth. Transportation was taking the first tenuous steps that would soon change the world forever. With the invention of the internal combustion engine in the late 19th century, new possibilities of motive force became available. By 1903 the automobile was set to challenge the horse.

Transportation would soon change even more dramatically because of a new

invention – the airplane. Within the century that followed, humankind took to the air, led by the pioneering example of Wilbur and Orville Wright. First in frail craft, but soon in sturdy and reliable machines, aviators shattered long-standing barriers of time and distance. By midcentury air travel was common, and by the late 1950s it had replaced the train and steamship as the preferred mode of transport. By the last quarter of the 20th century, with large, efficient jet-powered aircraft, air travel was commonplace and affordable to all. Flying has become second nature to hundreds of millions of people and is so deeply intertwined into the fabric of society that it is impossible to imagine a world without it. The airplane also rapidly developed as a weapon of war. Used widely during World War I, where

